The Auction

A player primer

An evening of remarkable objects, careful manners and people who want different things. This is a shared starting point for a tabletop role playing game (RPG) or a small parlour Live Action Role Play (L(A)RP). It contains player-facing material only.

Your invitation

An auction brings together people with money, connections or a reason to be near both. Attendants prepare the room, guests study the catalogue and the auctioneer calls each lot. Between sales there is time to talk, make offers and decide who deserves your trust.

You might be part of the security team, an uninvited visitor, a representative acting for someone else, or a patron bidding in your own right. Agree the version and your place in it with the Game Master (GM) or organiser before play. The host can adapt the venue and the lots to the group's setting; this primer does not establish a fixed catalogue or a guaranteed turn of events.

What everyone can reasonably know

- The sale is a public occasion for those admitted, not an open invitation to every room in the building.
- Lots are introduced by the auctioneer. A description is a claim made by the seller or host, not proof of an object's history or qualities.
- Guests may value the same object for very different reasons. A losing bid need not end a conversation.
- Staff have jobs to do. Ask before handling a lot or entering a space marked as private, and expect your character's choices to be noticed.

Who are you tonight?

Choose a viewpoint that fits the group's version of the auction. The prompts are invitations to invent your own character, not secret instructions or claims about other characters.

Security

You are responsible for keeping the event orderly. Who hired you, and what have you been asked to protect: people, property or the host's reputation? Where do you draw the line if those duties pull in different directions?

Uninvited visitor

You have a reason to be somewhere you are not expected. What are you hoping to learn or recover, and what would make you leave without it? Agree with the GM how your character has reached the occasion; do not assume access to restricted areas.

Proxy

You speak for an absent patron. What may you promise on their behalf? What limit have they placed on your spending or your discretion? Name one thing you want for yourself that is not in the brief.

Patron

You have come in your own right. What brought you an invitation: wealth, reputation, expertise or a useful relationship? What would you be prepared to risk for a lot, and what would you rather keep than win?

Make a connection

With another player's agreement, establish one connection before the sale: an old favour, a shared acquaintance or a previous disagreement. Decide what your characters know about it. Leave room for both people to surprise each other in play.

The shape of a sale

Listen as the auctioneer introduces a lot. If your character wants to bid, say so using the signal or procedure agreed for this event. Keep track of your fictional budget and any authority you have to spend it. The GM or organiser will explain increments, ties, payment and what happens if a bid is disputed; do not assume that a promise or a favour counts as money.

Between lots, seek out a conversation. You might ask about an object's provenance, look for a partner in a bid, or make an offer that has nothing to do with buying. A question, a new acquaintance or a decision not to bid can be as interesting as a purchase.

Reasons to pay attention

Use one of these open-ended prompts, or invent your own with the group:

- A family or community wants to know how a keepsake came to be offered.
- A scholar hopes to examine an unfamiliar instrument before it disappears into a private collection.
- A guest needs to speak with a rival without causing a public scene.
- A patron wants to be seen supporting a cause, whether or not they buy.
- A representative must choose between following instructions and preserving a relationship they value.

These are possible starting points, not statements about a particular lot or person. Ask the GM or organiser which fit the session.

A few manners

Introduce yourself as much or as little as your character wishes. Let the auctioneer be heard when a lot is called, and leave space for quieter players to act. You can challenge a claim, withdraw from a conversation or decline a deal. A character can be rude or deceptive without treating another player unkindly.

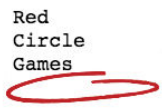
Playing comfortably together

Before play, agree the tone, boundaries and a way to pause or leave a scene without having to explain why. Check in out of character if a scene becomes uncomfortable. Anyone can ask for a change; the group can pause, rewind or move on. Character conflict is not permission to disregard a player's boundary.

For tabletop play, agree how the chosen game's rules handle social pressure, money and conflict. Describe what you want to do and let the GM explain when a rule or roll is needed.

For a parlour L(A)RP, use fictional money and clearly identified game props; do not bring real valuables into play. Agree before the event whether touch, moving props, private conversations and simulated conflict are permitted. Unless everyone has explicitly agreed otherwise, do not touch another person or take their belongings. A pause or an out-of-character departure always takes priority over staying in character. Costume and performance experience are optional.

About this companion



An original, unofficial **Red Circle Games** player companion, offered as a free site download. Written for the auction ideas discussed at Red Circle Games.

Inspired by *The Dwarven Auction*, written and illustrated by **Nimrod Cortés** and published by **OR15 Publishing**. This companion does not reproduce the original adventure's text, artwork or map and is not a replacement for it. It is not affiliated with or endorsed by its creator or publisher.

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